Case Study: Identity Theft

The 2023 ICMR Aadhaar Data Breach — 815 Million Records Exposed

---

What Is Identity Theft?

Identity theft occurs when a criminal steals personal information — name, ID numbers, biometrics, or financial details — and uses it to impersonate the victim for fraud, financial gain, or other malicious purposes. Unlike most cybercrimes, victims often remain unaware for months or even years.

The Incident

In October 2023, a threat actor using the alias **'pwn001'** posted on Breach Forums — a dark web platform for data trading — offering access to the personal records of **815 million Indian citizens**. The data allegedly originated from COVID-19 test records stored with the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR).

How It Happened — Step by Step

1. Attackers gained unauthorized access to ICMR's database containing citizen COVID-19 test registrations.
2. Sensitive data — including Aadhaar IDs, passport details, names, phone numbers, addresses, and biometrics — was extracted in bulk.
3. The stolen data was listed for sale on Breach Forums, accessible to cybercriminals worldwide.
4. Leaked Aadhaar IDs were independently verified as valid, confirming the breach was genuine.
5. The data could then be used to open bank accounts, apply for loans, or commit fraud under victims' identities.

Who Was Targeted?

Every Indian citizen who registered for a COVID-19 test through the ICMR system — cutting across age groups, professions, and states — was potentially affected.

Consequences

- Personal data of an estimated 815 million Indians was exposed — over half the country's population.
- Victims faced risks of financial fraud, fake loan applications, and SIM card cloning using their Aadhaar details.
- ICMR and the government did not issue an official public statement; the CBI was reported to be probing the matter.
- It highlighted a critical gap in data protection laws, preceding the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

Key Takeaway

Your Aadhaar number is not just an ID — it is a gateway to your financial and legal identity. A single breach can silently put millions at risk without them ever knowing.

Source: NetMission Case Study Series, 2024 — Cybersecurity Challenges in South Asia
netmission.asia